

HOW TO USE MODAL VERBS

1. Modals of Advice (建议)

should / shouldn't · 应该 / 不应该 (日常建议)

- You **should check** the metro schedule before leaving. (离开前你应该查一下地铁时刻表。)
- We **shouldn't order** takeout every night — cooking is healthier. (我们不该天天点外卖，自己做更健康。)
- You **should bring** an umbrella — the forecast says rain. (你应该带把伞，天气预报说有雨。)

had better / had better not · 最好 / 最好别 (强语气建议，含后果警示)

- You **had better submit** the report before 5 pm today. (你最好在今天下午五点前提交报告。)
- We **had better leave** now, or we will get stuck in traffic. (我们最好现在出发，否则会堵在路上。)
- She **had better not be** late — the team lead is upset. (她最好别迟到了，组长已经很不高兴了。)

ought to · 应当 / 应该 (常理、道义或规范建议)

- A new tenant **ought to check** the plumbing before moving in. (新租客入住前应当检查下水管道。)
- He **ought to start** jogging — his blood pressure is high. (他应当开始慢跑了，他的血压偏高。)
- Every employee **ought to back up** important project files. (每位员工都应当备份重要项目文件。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- What should a job applicant prepare before an online interview?
- What had an employee better not say during a performance review?
- How much money should a young worker save from their monthly salary?
- What ought a newcomer to do if they get lost in a large subway station?

2. Modals of Necessity (必要与义务)

must / must not · 必须 / 严禁 (刚性规定与禁止)

- Passengers **must scan** their QR code before boarding the train. (乘客上车前必须出示扫码。)
- Delivery riders **must wear** helmets while riding on city streets. (外卖骑手骑行时必须佩戴头盔。)
- You **must not smoke** anywhere inside this office building. (办公楼内任何区域都严禁吸烟。)

have to / don't have to · 不得不 / 不必 (客观需要与免除义务)

- I **have to renew** my apartment lease before the end of this month. (我必须在月底前续签租房合同。)
- He **has to work** overtime tomorrow even though it is Saturday. (虽然明天是周六，但他不得不加班。)
- You **don't have to come** to the office on remote work days. (居家办公日你不需要来办公室。)

have got to · 得 / 必须 (口语强调)

- We **have got to buy** a new rice cooker — ours is broken. (我们真得买个新电饭煲了，旧的坏了。)
- I **have got to finish** these slides before the 2 pm meeting. (我得在下午两点开会前把这几页 PPT 做完。)
- You **have got to try** this new coffee shop near the station. (你真得试试车站旁这家新开的咖啡店。)

had to · 当时不得不 (过去必要)

- She **had to take** a taxi because the bus was delayed. (因为公交车晚点了，她当时不得不打车。)
- We **had to cancel** the camping trip due to the heavy rain. (因为暴雨，我们当时不得不取消露营计划。)
- He **had to stay** at the office until midnight to fix the server. (为了修服务器，他昨晚不得不待到半夜。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- What daily tasks do you have to finish before clocking out?
- What safety rules must passengers follow on high-speed trains?
- Why do office workers have to check messaging apps during the day?
- What documents do you have to prepare when renting an apartment?

3. Modals of Possibility and Probability (推测与把握程度)

must · 一定 / 肯定 (95% 把握的肯定推测)

- The café is packed — their new seasonal drink **must be** good. (咖啡馆挤满了人，他们的新品一定很好喝。)
- The lights are still on — he **must be** working on the proposal. (灯还亮着，他肯定还在加班赶方案。)
- You've been in meetings all day — you **must be** exhausted. (你开了一整天会，现在一定累坏了。)

may / could · 也许 / 可能 (50%–60% 把握的中等推测)

- It **may rain** this afternoon — look at those dark clouds. (下午可能会下雨，看天上的乌云。)
- If you leave right now, you **could catch** the 6:15 train. (如果你现在出发，也许能赶上 6 点 15 分的班次。)
- We **may receive** the bonus announcement by next Friday. (我们可能在下周五前收到发奖金的通知。)

might / might not · 或许 / 可能不 (30%–40% 把握的低确定推测)

- He **might be** stuck on subway Line 10 during rush hour. (早高峰他或许正堵在地铁 10 号线上。)
- The room is empty — the team **might be** having lunch outside. (会议室是空的，团队或许出去吃午饭了。)
- The food delivery **might not arrive** on time in this storm. (雨这么大，外卖可能无法按时送达。)

can't · 不可能 (95% 把握的否定推测)

- That **can't be** Li Wei at the desk — he is in Shenzhen today. (前台不可能是李伟，他今天在深圳出差。)
- This electric car **can't be** out of power — I charged it today. (这辆电车不可能没电，我今天刚充满。)
- It **can't be** 7 pm already — my watch says only 5:30. (不可能已经晚上七点了，我表上才五点半。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- If a milk tea shop has a long line, what must customers think?
- Why might it be hard to hail a ride on a rainy Friday evening?
- If a coworker looks totally exhausted, what could have happened?
- What AI tools or smart devices might change office work soon?

4. Modals of Past Regret · 本来…… (表达后悔与遗憾)

should have done · 本该做…… (遗憾没做)

- I **should have set** two alarms — I woke up 30 minutes late. (我本该设两个闹钟的，今天起晚了半小时。)
- We **should have booked** the train earlier — tickets are sold out. (我们本该早点订高铁票的，现在票卖光了。)
- He **should have backed up** his files before updating the OS. (他本该在更新系统前备份文件的。)

shouldn't have done · 本不该做…… (后悔做了)

- I **shouldn't have eaten** that spicy hot pot — my stomach hurts. (我真不该吃那么辣的火锅，胃好难受。)
- We **shouldn't have waited** until Friday to start this slide deck. (我们本不该拖到周五才开始做这份 PPT。)
- She **shouldn't have replied** to that angry email late at night. (她真不该在深夜回复那封带情绪的邮件。)

could have done · 本来可以…… (本有能力或机会做，但未做)

- I **could have taken** the direct subway, but I took the slow bus. (我本来可以坐地铁直达的，却坐了慢车。)
- We **could have negotiated** lower rent with a two-year lease. (如果我们签两年租约，本来可以谈下更低房租。)
- You **could have asked** a coworker for help instead of staying late. (你本来可以找同事帮忙的，而不必加班到深夜。)

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- What is something you should have done differently on your last trip?
- What is a recent purchase you feel you shouldn't have bought?
- What routine task at work could you have handled more efficiently?
- What makes you think, "I should have left home ten minutes earlier"?